From the Sunrise to the Next

The second book

PART I

Sunrise

After a period of focus and tranquility, the man found himself haunted: dilemmas, lack of direction, confusion. Everything felt stagnant and repetitive. His health, too, was far less than ideal — constant tiredness, no focus. It was unclear how he accomplished anything at all.

In many ways there seemed nothing to do but stay put, work hard, and stop thinking so much. Yet something inside kept eating at him: the sense of wasting time, of unfulfilled potential. Feedback hardly ever came, and he feared he wasn't growing. Perhaps he demanded too much of himself.

When he felt low, he held onto an old insight from his youth: that redemptive years lay ahead of him. Now, he felt, they were near.

When the time came, he traveled to the resting place of a previous lion — one he had always admired and felt close to. The trip was full of expectation, and ended in confusion.

Six months later he returned, this time with his son — and this time it was clear. He reached the Promised Land with his family, and saw his old friends the Angel and the Lamb. He visited his ancestors' resting places, and came home with something of the spirit of his first return there. Then, with his son beside him, he visited the resting place of the Great Lion, in the Land of the Dogs — and that visit shone.

He remembered the first message he had received from the Great Lion: that he was very spiritual, and should be a teacher. And he remembered what had flashed through him when his son was born, the cub fiery as the sun: that to be a lion means to transmit everything learned until now.

Back in the Land of the Sweet Waters, things began to improve. He had more energy; the work grew more interesting; he was given more young cubs to teach. And the more he taught, the clearer it became: he had always been meant to be a teacher.

There was repetition again — but it no longer felt stagnant. In truth it had been the challenge all along, the message received at the very beginning of his journeys.

It happened the way everything happened in those years: almost all at once. He joined a new house of prayer, took up new work, and even a new way to share the book, and started teaching at a new school, all of this while the man and his family moved into a new house.

PART II

Noon

He was called back to the various lands he once inhabited, and in each one he would now play a different role.

The Land of the Pigs, Again

Rome

In the house of prayer, the man found his place the way he always found it: as the stand-in. When the rabbi was away, he taught. Even here, in the holy place, there were turf wars; the exile does not disappear.

But beneath the turf, two deeper roles held him, which together were reminiscent of the zealous priest who became a prophet. The first was the provider's. The second was to raise his hands in blessing — and this, if you asked anyone, was his true role.

Yet the air of the house of prayer was thick with the very thing the land had always breathed: gold. That air of self-importance, that drive for wealth and standing, the utmost focus on professional success — the pig-energy, was still there, but elevated. Every time a man went up to the reading, a gift was expected, and announced aloud. Every honor of the holidays was auctioned or bought. Money was everywhere — and the man's work was to elevate it further: to turn the money-talk toward Heaven and the hearts toward each other. It worked, and it didn't. You could elevate the gold and still be shocked by its effects.

To stand in the elevated Land of the Pigs, among the gold and the appetites, to raise his hands in powerful blessings of peace — was to be a lion for them.

The Land of the Bulls, Again

Greece

The gate of this land was a dream. Years earlier, walking in the courts of the Great Lion, the man had looked into the eyes of a man of great physical strength and found the Great Lion's eyes, and been pulled upward, level upon level upon level. He had asked the Great Lion how he could be a teacher if he was already on his way to the land, to learn its ways? And the Great Lion had said: do it — but do it for the Book.

Great Lion taught him that the laws of the Bulls could be used for the Book itself, and now returning to the Land he was charged with keeping its integrity. Integrity — wholeness, the unbroken thing. The word became his watchword, and his test.

And over the integrity he watched, there stood a figure from the old stories: the dreamer sold by his brothers, raised to the viceroy's seat — never the king, but the one through whose vision the kingdom ran, doing what had to be done from the background, true to his values when everything around him bent. Keeping the program true, the man understood, was the viceroy's integrity.

Once, his work had been weighed and corrected by court officials. Then he became one who weighed. Now he did a third thing: he mended the judgments of others. He corrected, revised, edited; he mentored the younger officials. Among the bulls he had been an ox for them — the steady shoulder under the yoke, the steady mending, decision by decision.

The Land of the Cats, Again

Persia

As a boy, he had arrived in the Land of the Cats with his ears closed and left with them open — the Rabbit had taught him that: keep the ears and the eyes wide open, and the Teacher will appear. He had been a toucan there, colorful and light, flying from sunrise to sunrise. It was the one land where he had really begun to discover himself.

He returned there with the same spirit of discovery. However, this time, he was not looking for guides to the texts, nor for rabbits to lead the way. This time, he was there to bring everything together, and build it into a system. Everything he had

learned, applied. And the land itself he found in a place without ground — the feeds, the screens — a land of scattering, as the enemy of his people once told its king: one people, scattered and dispersed through all his provinces. It would be made inside that land, out of its own materials: a focus and a healing for it, from within.

For years it had been a book and a journal, added to slowly, entry by entry. Then a new instrument arrived — and the work went exponential. What had been pages became a living calendar: every day marked, many ways at once, the whole system complete, interactive and awake. It all happened with tremendous power and speed, both uplifting and intoxicating.

The key to the old-new approach: to see not only each month and each week, but the smaller cycles too — each day, each moment. Every day a whole year, opening with the new year and closing with repentance. Every day, the Book received anew and transmitted to the next generation. Every day: faith, gratitude, love, joy — and the equanimity of feeling that all things rest in the Teacher's hands.

The system also had the potential to focus the generation's scattered attention. What the work asked of him was something of the humble shepherd of faith, who rose to the mountain to bring down knowledge, and who was willing to sacrifice everything for the sake of his people's liberation.

The system did what the Rabbit had taught: to keep the student ready. The man's lifelong discipline, the daily returning, which had started in earnest in the Land of the Cats, now had a home.

In that system there was tremendous purpose, healing, joy and satisfaction. He loved it the way a father loves. It was, he sometimes thought, like a fifth child — made, nurtured, worried over, watched growing.

The boy who had flown in this land before as a light and colorful toucan, now flew with purpose and for the sake of guidance and protection: he became an eagle for others.

The Land of the Dogs, Again

Babylonia

At thirty-six, the man reached back toward the school he had once refused. Thirty-six: the same age at which a previous lion had taken charge of the school. What he had not expected was how much he would learn.

To teach the storytellers of the land, he had to read their tales. To teach the speeches of its orators, he had to hear them. Its rulers, one by one; its rememberers, one of whom had seen the darkest places and still spoke of the light. And the sciences: biology, the intricate machinery of living things; later economics, government, history. Each subject was a room, and in each room, if he looked carefully, there was a window — and through the window, the same landscape: the beauty of the world, the role of its people, and everything connecting back to the Book. In this journey he felt like the prophet from the Book he was named after.

This was the work: extraction. The man's daily labor was to find what was clean, to wash what could be washed, to lift out the spark and leave the shell. And he was helped. Again and again, the right tools appeared at the right time, as if the work itself were being assisted by the Great Lion. After all, the elevated Land of the Dogs was renamed after the Great Lions.

He left and returned. He left again and returned again. He left yet again and this time, he felt, he had returned for good. Teaching demanded the skills and qualities acquired in all the other lands. The more he taught, the more he understood what the Great Lion had meant. To be a teacher is to learn in order to teach, and to teach in order to do. The boy had been guided and supported in this land by the Badger and the Hound, and now it was his turn to guide and support the young cubs, as a man.

The school, he saw, had never been a building: every land had been a classroom, and he had been a student in each one long before he was anyone's teacher.

The Land of the Donkeys, Again

Egypt

Quite unexpectedly, the man found himself again in the Land of the Donkeys, returned and repaired, in the man's own house. His wife and her family, after all, had also spent their early years there.

The house felt, in ways he could not fully explain, like his mother's house. The children playing in the street outside — he watches and is seven years old again.

Walk through it, the way he walks through it each evening. Each part of the house holds its life: the rooms where the children sleep and argue and grow; the table where the family eats; the corners where the books live. Then the pool — the small private sea in the backyard, the children's summer kingdom. Then beyond, not far, the beach: the great water, the horizon. Every part reminds him of his own childhood home.

And sometimes, standing at the beach with the great water before him, he thinks of his mother across the ocean — and in his mind he waves to her, and she waves back. The exile and the home in a single gesture: the son who left, the mother who stayed, the water between them no longer a separation but a medium. The wave travels. And behind her, over the sand where she stands, two peaks rise — the two brothers.

In this land, the boy is also a donkey: the strong, humble back on which the family rides. His role was like that of the sage that was the foundation of it all. The one that keeps everyone and everything together through holiness and love. For the donkey, the man finally understood, is the carrier. The humble animal, the beast of burden — the carrier of treasures, the one the old prophecies seat the king upon. And his wife and children are by far his greatest treasure.

PART III

Sunset

On the eve of the Seventh Day, they sit around the table, and the man blesses the wine, and looks across at his wife and four children — and sees the chariot.

Four faces: the Man/Leopard, the Eagle, the Ox/Deer, the Lioness. The man looks at his children and sees them, each week transformed.

Every one of the creatures bore all four faces; what set one from another was only which of them led. So these are four ways of standing, not four portions.

Water, air, earth, fire, water. Bold as the leopard, light as the eagle, swift as the deer, strong as the lion — to do the will of the Teacher.

And the same four stand in the system he had built in the Land of the Cats, a season to each: the eagle's air in the fall, the man's water in the winter, the ox's earth in the spring, the lion's fire in the summer, each under its own angel. The table and the calendar had come out the same.

At night the man prays the old prayer — to his right the angel of kindness, to his left the angel of strength, before him the angel of light, behind him the angel of healing, and above them all the Divine Presence. He prays it, and sees his family: the eldest to his right, the lioness to his left, the eagle before him, the ox behind, supporting — and above them all, his wife.

And sitting at the table, he saw the pattern whole. Going out: lion, ox, eagle, man. At the centre, the donkey. Coming home: man, eagle, ox, lion. The same four faces read one way and then the other, with the house at the turn.

And through every land and every form, the direction was the same: to be reliable, constant, like the sun, living in the moment, from the sunrise to the next.

The Eldest

The eldest began as a cub — fiery, solar, all pounce. His name, in two tongues, held the first letters of them all: his brothers, his sisters, and the book itself. He is the Face of Man: the human face is the one that contains all the others.

He is water, the element that takes every shape — and he is also the fish, hidden in the waters, holding everything. Bold as the leopard now, the cub's fire grown into courage, tenacity and perseverance. A chess player and a cantor. They say the one who returns stands where even the righteous cannot; the eldest is the king of return.

The Eagle

The second started as a moon, a shining olive tree. With her light she overpowers the darkness. A voracious reader with an expansive mind and an artist's hand. Beautiful, and a maker of beauty. A valiant warrior-queen, her greatest weapons: her guitar and her voice.

And so, she became the Eagle, without ceasing to be either. She soars — high, brilliant, near the sun. She has a special way with children, and her sweetness and kindness towards them keeps bringing her home: one act at a time. Air is her element — and she is loving and nurturing in it: the eagle that carries its young on its wings.

The Ox

The third started as a wolf, with the beautiful qualities of a deer. He also became an Ox — wolf's edge, deer's gentleness, ox's shoulder, all kept. Determined, competitive, disciplined; never a bad word about anyone crosses his lips. A model priest: constant, consistent. He plans and executes with precision. Named after his great-grandfather, a tennis player, a loyal friend, with his grandfather's taste for ice cream.

Gifted in math, his success appears effortless, but the labor and emotion is all there, hidden. There is a wonderful calmness to him — understanding, conscientious, respectful — wise in keeping things simple. Earth is his element — and he holds it.

The Lioness

The fourth had begun as a Lioness-Star, and so she remains. Royal and friendly — a gracious queen, a leader, a super star. While the others transformed, she was always herself.

And she dances beautifully and gracefully — like her mother. She goes with the flow, adapting to whoever is in front of her; she knows how to enjoy life, she is expressive and warm, and it shows in her dance. But the ease is what the fire makes: she is driven, in the dance and in everything else. Fire is her element, but the dance pulls her waterward: the lioness who moves like water, with her beautiful smile.

The Mother

And above them all, his wife. The little girl become woman. The warrior, the engine that makes it all possible.

For she is the Presence above: the mother who weeps and prays for her children, refusing comfort until they are home. And she is the doer below — the hands that hold the house together. The will is the crown above; the doing is the kingdom below — and she is both.

Their life together moves in waves, and it is not without its challenges: the raising and the providing, on every level — the mind's, the heart's, the mouth's, the stomach's. Many times the waters have run high, and yet, as the Book affirms: great waters cannot extinguish love. And they haven't. The Great Lion has taught: the waters don't destroy — they purify, and they lift. And they deepened the bond — wave upon wave, year upon year — into a partnership built on tremendous love and admiration for each other.

PART IV

Midnight

His father and mother lived their separate lives, as they long had. His mother is an ocean away, and yet always present. His father, close by, spends time with his family on an almost weekly basis.

At the eldest's eighteenth his father came to the house: the long table, the grandchildren gathered round it, the candles blown out. The father who left the first home sat down at the second. Then he took the boy to lunch, as he had taken the man at eighteen.

On the seventh of October,[1] a day after his brother's birthday, the man lay in bed thinking about this book and thinking about his brother, and in that same moment the message came: his brother's daughter had made her father a book for his birthday, and her father was sending it on.

The mending was not their parents' to complete; it was his and his brother's — the homes held together, the table around which the chariot sat, the river that took his brother on a basket now turned to flow both ways.

And the mending, the man understood at last, is the sun's work. The sun sweetens the fruit. It does not ripen by force. It sweetens — the judgments, the home, the brothers — until the bitter turns drinkable. From the new moon to the next: the moon learning, month by month, to shine like the sun. From the sunrise to the next: the sweetening, continuing.

Epilogue

His brother's daughter — the little niece, born on the day that stands as the foundation of the entire book — the day of the donkey[2] — had made it by hand for her father's birthday: written it out in pencil, pasted photographs into it, and drawn what the photographs did not have. It reached the uncle as pictures of its pages, at night, on a phone.

It began: once upon a time in a faraway land, there lived a baby named David. His parents were Sandra and Alan. David was born in New York. In the same hospital as me.

In two books of faraway lands the man had never once written a name. The child began in his own words and wrote all of them.

Beneath those lines she had pasted a photograph: two boys, the older dark-haired in a white collar with his arm around the younger, holding him steady; the younger blonde, in red, looking straight out at whoever held the camera. Three and a half years between them. In the first book that younger one is the boy in the basket, carried away. Here he is being held.

On the next page: David has one brother and one sister — I will tell you more about the sister later. In her book too, the sister comes later.

And she had drawn them, the two brothers standing side by side on the page, each named underneath in pencil.

A month before any of it, his sister had sent a photograph from the Land of the Donkeys to him and his brother, as well as to his stepbrother and stepsister: a family tree she had drawn at school thirty years before, with both her families on the one page — two of them beside her, two across an ocean, and herself in the middle. Even back then she mentioned how she liked the new instant communication technology. Now the world had become even smaller. "De avião o tempo de uma saudade."[3]

At Thanksgiving they played tennis. Four took the court: the man, his brother, his son, and his stepsister on his father's side. His father sat above and watched.

The uncle who writes books received a book from a child who writes books. From the new moon to the next. From the sunrise to the next.[4] It wasn't always easy — but it turned out well. It was very good.

NOTES

[1] In 2023 the seventh of October was Shemini Atzeret — the birthday of the man's mother-in-law and co-author, who appears in the first book — and the day the darkness fell. By 2026 her Hebrew birthday had moved to the third; the civil date had not moved at all. That the mending should arrive on it: darkness turning into light. The other date does the same. On the 11th of Adar — the man's birthday — the war with Iran began, February 28, 2026: Shabbat Zachor, three days before Purim, the same Shabbat he was born on. In the month of Purim, in the land of the Purim story, everything turned upside down.

[2] The day of the donkey is Lag Ba'Omer, the thirty-third day of the Omer — Hod within Hod — and the day of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, who brought the hidden Torah out of a cave. In the system the man built, it is the thirty-third week, whose creature is the donkey, and whose song in Perek Shirah is the verse that names the sefirot one by one: the greatness, the might, the splendor, the victory, the glory, all that is in heaven and earth, and the kingship. Chamor, donkey, is written with the letters of chomer, matter — the animal that carries, and in carrying raises what it carries. It is also the day the dying stopped among Rabbi Akiva's students, who had died for want of respect between them: a day for mending between brothers.

[3] Portuguese: "By plane, the time of one saudade" — a line from "Parabolicamará," Gilberto Gil's song. Saudade is the longing for an absent loved one — in Hebrew, ga'aguim, the longing that runs through the Song of Songs.

[4] The finished book was sent, in an instant, to the man's father and mother — who were then in the Land of the Sunrise, whose flag is a sun. As a boy, the man had woken every morning to another of Gilberto Gil's songs, "Oriente": "Orient yourself, young man, by the rotation of the Earth around the Sun; smiling, by the continuity of Adam's dream."